



18 THINGS DIGIT PREDICTED AND HOW THEY PANNED OUT

01

AUTONOMOUS CARS

In our first Digit issue ever, we predicted that we could have driverless cars with navigation systems that can take people from Mumbai to New Delhi autonomously. That particular drive is difficult enough for humans as it is, and we are still a long way away from Level 5 autonomous cars in India.

02

QUANTUM DOT CELLS

We predicted the use of quantum dot cells in technology back in 2001, and this is one of the predictions that eventually came true, although later than anticipated. Samsung became one of the first companies to incorporate quantum dot cells in consumer technology, with the QLED displays introduced at CES 2017. The displays provide a wider colour gamut than regular displays.

03

WIRELESS INPUT DEVICES

In 2002, we correctly predicted the future ubiquity of LCD displays when CRTs were the norm, and the rise of the SATA interface for hard drives for future data requirements. One thing we got wrong was the proliferation of wireless input devices. Not a single person in the Digit office uses a wireless keyboard and mouse, as we have found out that wires are not as much of a hassle that they were made out to be.

Digit writes a lot of future looking articles, and anniversary issue was good reason to take stock of how accurate these conjectures have been over the years

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04

VIDEO STREAMING

In 2002, a number of major Hollywood studios including MGM, Paramount, WB and Universal worked with Microsoft and RealNetworks to kickstart video streaming services, which was then known as "online rental". While we correctly predicted that there would be legal alternatives to movie piracy, we simply could not anticipate services unaffiliated with technology or studios to take the lead - like Netflix has done.

05

NATURAL LANGUAGE PROCESSING

Way back in 2003, we predicted that in the future we would be able to talk to our computers using NLP, long before it became a buzzword. This has come true, with the proliferation of personal assistants such as Siri and Alexa, as well as IoT enabled devices that can control lights and appliances in our homes. The only thing we do not yet have are personal robots that can pour out coffee.

06

CONVERGENCE

We correctly anticipated multiple handheld devices

merging into one device that could do everything - the cell phone. In 2003, PDAs and mobile phones were vying with each other to become this one device, and this was a time when PMPs were popular too. Back then, it was borderline science fiction to get notifications, and buy a product after sending an image to your better half.

07

SUB 10K PCS

In 2004, hardware prices were falling and the Government had announced cuts on import duties, so it was reasonable to believe that cheap computing was in the offing, with PCs becoming as cheap as stereo systems or televisions. Inflation meant that the prices of all these electronics went up, but it is technically just about possible to build a working PC for less than Rs 10,000.

08

THE INTERNET 2.0

Digit outlined some possible future applications enabled by faster internet speeds in 2004. These included realtime lectures and analysis of satellite data. Both of these have come true. Digit also predicted that remote surgery would be the